gradually adopted the Soviet doctrine. The practical significance of this change was the Soviet supply, over many years, of land, naval, and air weapons systems to Iraq. This was of great interest to Israel. Some of this intelligence made its way to Israel even before Egypt and Syria received the Soviet weapons systems supplied to Iraq. And this was another good reason for the Mossad chief's concern that I might return to Israel from my mission to Iran with the key of our foreign outpost there.

The six months following my meeting with Meir Amit were dedicated to training for the mission. Every day, several hours were devoted to the study and practice of the theory of clandestine activity. I took daily Persian lessons with a tutor and studied Iraqi Arabic intensively under the guidance of Ibn al-Rafidain, the legendary broadcaster who broadcast from the Voice of Israel to Iraq in their colloquial tongue each week. For two months, I was assigned to the southern base of Military Intelligence's HUMINT unit, in order to study their activities. The list went on. Separately, Yael studied photography, the development and management of a secret photo lab, and a lot of clandestine activity.

My training continued for two more months in Tehran, where my daily agenda consisted of one or two Persian lessons and a few hours of wandering through Tehran's bazaar to practice the language, strengthen my cover story, and get to know the city, its commerce, and its residents.

For two and a half years, we lived in Iran's southwestern province, whose southern border is the Persian Gulf and whose western border is shared with Iraq. This border was not marked, as it lay inside the huge delta created by flow of the Euphrates and the Tigris from northern to southern Iraq. The delta stretched out over hundreds of square kilometers of water, some of it flowing but most of it standing and forming huge swamps that were full of life. The swamps were surrounded by dense and impenetrable wild vegetation, most of it reeds, and groves of trees that rose high above the swamp into which their roots were sunk. Small villages were scattered around the perimeter of the swamp; the raw material for their houses were reeds that were woven to create outer walls, rounded roofs, and interior rooms. All of the houses stood on stilts that were sunken into the swamp water, and the only vehicles were primitive boats of various sizes, most of which were used for transport though others were used for fishing, which provided most of the villagers' food.